VACATIONS BY RAIL

THE VERY BEST OF OUR

RIVER CRUISE VACATIONS

2026



CELEBRATING OVER 20 VBR YEARS OF TOUR EXPERTISE

From the stunning Swiss Alps to the romantic rivers of Germany and Portugal's gleaming wine regions,

we've perfected the art of travel.

Founded more than 20 years ago with a passion for rail travel, today we are proud to also offer exclusively chartered ships which provide an impressive range of cruises along Europe's wonderful waterways.

Inside is a selection of our very best river cruises. Sail with us into the UNESCO-listed Rhine Gorge, discover the imperial cities of the Danube or visit medieval towns along the Rhine. From the Seine to the Douro, experience Europe's natural beauty and cultural heritage as you travel with the experts.

In addition to some of our most popular tours, such as the **Classic Blue Danube** and **Paris, Provence & the Elegant Rhône**, we're delighted to introduce our unique **Tours & Cruise** itineraries, which combine our award-winning rail expertise and our cruise know-how to create a spectacular European vacation.

I hope you enjoy this selection and we look forward to exploring Europe's rivers with you in 2026.

Dave Riley

Dave Riley,
CEO, Great Rail Journeys family



COLOGNE



VACATIONS BY RAIL

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The most captivating way to see Europe

Each day, your river cruise brings refreshing views and new adventures. Sailing through beautiful, ever-changing scenery, we stop at historic cities and picturesque towns, exploring cultural highlights and hidden gems.

We take care of all the details

With a Cruise Director and a welcoming, professional crew onboard your ship, fascinating excursions, all meals and a selection of drinks with dinner – your needs are covered on our luxury cruises!

Expert guidance

We explore each port of call with an expert Cruise Director and a knowledgeable local guide. You enjoy a choice of well-planned excursions, that capture the most interesting sights and experiences of every destination.

Famous landmarks and unsung treasures

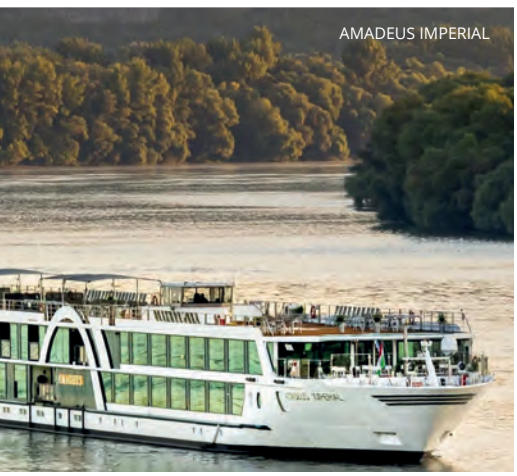
Both feature in our diverse itineraries. Besides showing you the main attractions of Europe's historic cities, we also explore less-visited sites and take in the most scenic natural beauty spots along our route.

Superb cuisine and service

Using fresh ingredients to provide delicious meals reflecting the regions we explore, our chefs pride themselves on serving food of the highest standard, supported by the exceptional service provided by our attentive and dedicated onboard crew.

Set sail with the experts

Decades of experience and a legacy of perfecting tours is embodied in each and every one of our river cruises. As a sister company of Great Rail Journeys, we leverage their European expertise to craft exceptional river cruising experiences. For more than 20 years, we've created amazing vacations, built exciting itineraries and continue to refine them each new season, using our award-winning travel expertise and exceptional customer service to deliver unforgettable experiences for our many wonderful customers. We look forward to welcoming you aboard.



AMADEUS IMPERIAL

Discover Europe with local experts

Wherever you travel with us, you'll experience destinations through the eyes of local guides.
We believe in supporting local people, and love how their knowledge and expertise gives us an insight into the stories beyond the surface of popular sites and classic landmarks.





We take care of all the details

An onboard Cruise Director is available 24/7, taking care of everything and assisting you with anything you may need. Simply unwind, soak up the beautiful scenery and enjoy each unique experience.



AMADEUS STAR

Flexible excursions

With a superb choice of well-planned excursions included in the price, we explore each port of call with our expert Cruise Director and knowledgeable local guides.

Intimate Experience

Our carefully selected chartered ships offer a luxurious experience with fewer than 200 guests, ensuring a comfortable and opulent journey to Europe's amazing destinations.

Inclusive Experience

Enjoy an excellent dining experience on our ships. All meals are included, plus a free drinks package that covers a wide selection of beverages.

Flexible options to join our ships

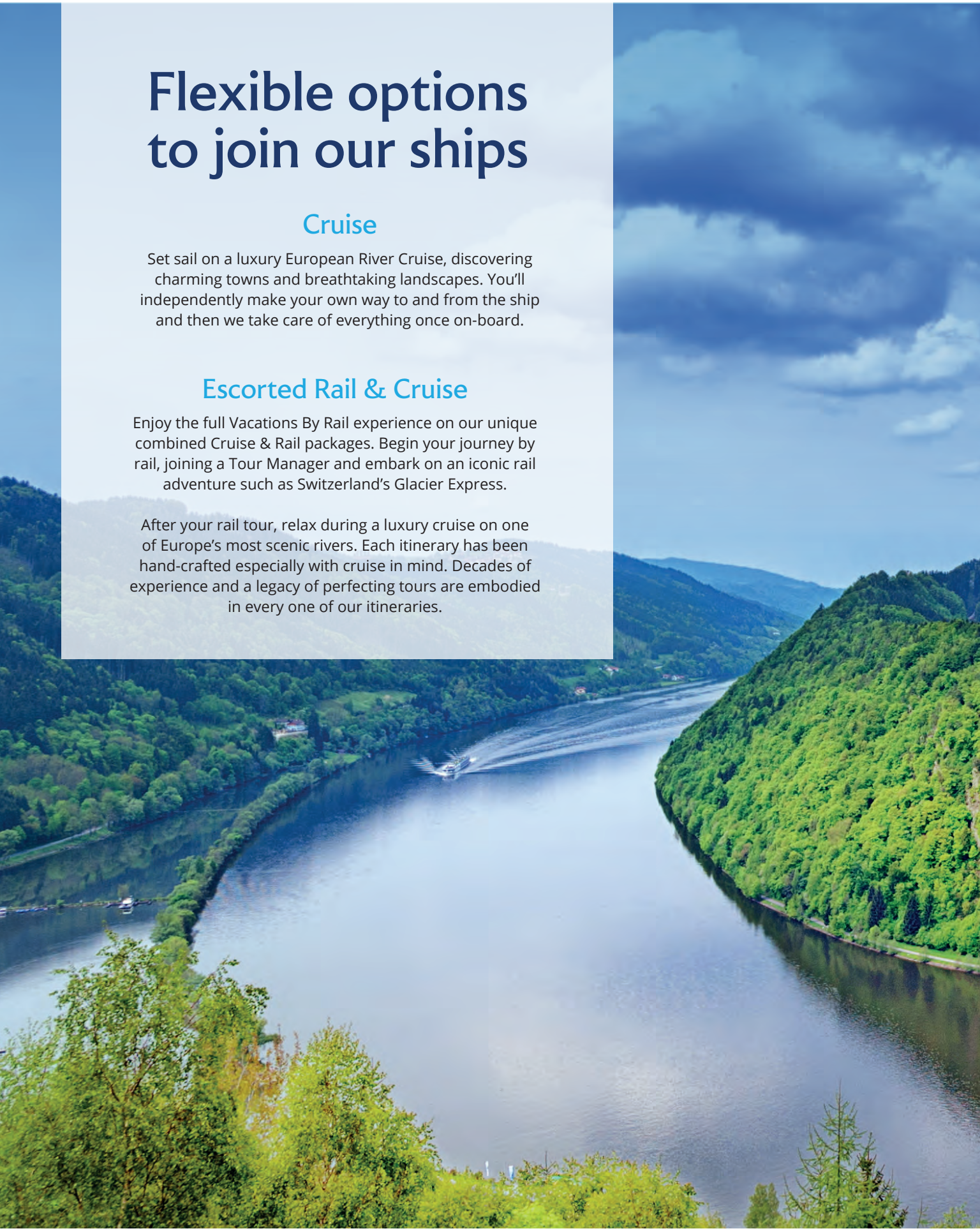
Cruise

Set sail on a luxury European River Cruise, discovering charming towns and breathtaking landscapes. You'll independently make your own way to and from the ship and then we take care of everything once on-board.

Escorted Rail & Cruise

Enjoy the full Vacations By Rail experience on our unique combined Cruise & Rail packages. Begin your journey by rail, joining a Tour Manager and embark on an iconic rail adventure such as Switzerland's Glacier Express.

After your rail tour, relax during a luxury cruise on one of Europe's most scenic rivers. Each itinerary has been hand-crafted especially with cruise in mind. Decades of experience and a legacy of perfecting tours are embodied in every one of our itineraries.



Your cruise, your way

Enjoying a luxury river cruise has never been easier. However you want to explore Europe, we offer a range of options which give you flexibility over your vacation. Choose between traveling on our exclusive cruise ships for your full vacation or book with a scenic rail tour at the beginning or end of your cruise. Whichever type of package you choose, River Cruising is the perfect blend of relaxation and exploration.



Five-star luxury onboard

Experience the high life as you cruise, with all the amenities and comfort you could possibly need, from exceptional dining and elegant cabins to world-class hospitality.



Welcome aboard our exclusive Amadeus ship – a floating luxury hotel, taking you to Europe's natural, historic and cultural delights.

Amadeus is an Austrian family-owned company with over 40 years of river cruise experience, setting the highest standards of quality and innovative routes. They were one of the first companies to introduce cruise ships on the Danube and we are proud to call them a trusted partner. You'll also enjoy exceptional and attentive service from our dedicated crew.



THE MAJESTIC RHINE

Effortless travel means viewing picturesque towns and scenic waterways from fabulous vantage points, while enjoying the calm atmosphere and comfort of our ship.



SUN DECK, AMADEUS IMPERIAL



SUN DECK

Stylish and comfortable interiors and exceptional service, create a feeling of freedom and relaxation as we sail through fascinating landscapes, watching the world drift by from the sun deck or enjoying a tasty selection of sandwiches and cakes from the panoramic bar. After a day on shore, our ship offers a welcoming, calm and luxurious environment.


CLUB BAR, AMADEUS STAR

Indulge yourself with exceptional onboard facilities, including a club bar, hair salon, massage and fitness rooms, and an onboard gift shop.


DELUXE SUITE, AMADEUS STAR

Upgrade to a Deluxe Suite for the ultimate cruising experience Features include a walk-out exterior balcony, a corner sofa, choice of double or twin beds, TV, climate control and en suite bathroom. For more details, see page 16.


CLUB BAR, AMADEUS STAR

Dine in superb quality

Experience culinary excellence in a relaxing onboard restaurant, where our chefs prepare regional dishes and their own specialties. Each dish is crafted with the freshest local ingredients and presented with exquisite attention to detail. Our menus showcase international and local cuisine – wherever your itinerary takes you.





The finest, locally sourced ingredients

We support and build links with trusted, local suppliers of high-end produce in each port of call. This ensures your meals are always freshly prepared and reflect the variety of dishes in the regions we sail through.



Enjoy an exceptional dining experience

The onboard restaurant offers the finest local and international cuisine. Savor extensive breakfast and lunch buffets, before our chef presents regional specialities for dinner. Vegetarian options are offered for all meals. Complimentary coffee and tea are available all day, and a selection of soft and alcoholic drinks is included with dinner. On the final or penultimate night, we enjoy a special gala dinner.



AMADEUS STAR, RESTAURANT



"As we cruise, the freshness and quality of the food served is always of the highest standard. The only changes are the variety of local flavors."

GRJ Cruise Manager



Savor wines and beers with regional dishes

Each evening, dinner is served with a selection of complimentary drinks. Besides branded soft drinks and a house draft beer, these include regional or local wines, meaning your drinks are well-paired with the delicious food.



Behind the Journey...

We meet the people who help make our journeys so memorable.



LUCY RALPH - CRUISE DIRECTOR

What aspects of your role do you find most fulfilling?
Knowing that you give the customers their best cruise experience. It's a very varied role, but the reward is hearing *"This is our first river cruise ever, but it won't be our last."*

Is there anything passengers love most about river cruise holidays?
From the moment passengers join the cruise they can relax knowing everything is taken care of. There is a flexibility of choice, from dining to excursions and entertainment. You have the opportunity to join exciting trips ashore, take a bike out, stroll into one of the wonderful towns or stay onboard and relax in the comfort of our floating hotel.

Could you share highlights of cruising specific rivers?
Of course, the Lorelei Rock beside the Rhine Gorge always springs to mind. Also, sailing the Danube, you pass through so many countries, each adding their own unique stamp to the river. However, one of my favorites is gliding past vineyards and marveling at the bird song along the serene Moselle with its picturesque villages and sleepy towns.

Any lesser-known river cruises you recommend?
I love the Garonne because it is steeped in maritime history and flows alongside famous vineyards. I also cannot forget the Seine, from the charms of Paris to Versailles, Giverny, and Rouen. Then there's the Rhône with the heady scents and gastronomy of the south, the breathtaking scenery of the Ardèche Gorge and the wildlife of the Camargue.

Have I fallen in love with the rivers of Europe? Of course, if you hadn't already guessed it!

REASONS TO SAIL ON THE RHINE RIVER

The Rhine River, often called the "Romantic Rhine", is one of Europe's most celebrated waterways. Stretching more than 750 miles, it flows through six countries, including Switzerland, Germany and the Netherlands.

Highlights:

- **The Rhine Gorge**, a UNESCO World Heritage site, is the pinnacle of this river. Here, you'll cruise past a stunning collection of more than 40 castles and fortresses, picturesque vineyards, and the legendary Lorelei Rock, where ancient folklore tells of a siren luring sailors to their doom.
- **Cologne** is home to the magnificent, twin-spired Cologne Cathedral, a Gothic masterpiece and UNESCO-listed site. A stop here allows you to explore this architectural wonder and the Old Town.
- **Strasbourg**, with its charming half-timbered houses and scenic canals in the Petite France district, offering a mix of French and German influences.
- **The scenic Black Forest region**, where thick woodlands and charming villages provide a stunning contrast to the river's grandeur.

Best for:

- History enthusiasts and lovers of medieval landscapes. The Rhine is perfect for those seeking a mix of natural beauty and cultural exploration.


COLOGNE



ROB LIPPIT - CRUISE DIRECTOR

When and why did you become a Cruise Director?
After several years with Vacations By Rail, I escorted many groups to a diverse range of destinations. In 2019, I joined the company's inaugural sailings and relished the challenge of looking after groups and co-ordinating an onboard team.

What are some great features of the river cruise ships you've worked on?
The cruise itself is a superb experience onboard our luxurious ships, with stylish interiors, fine dining and impeccable service delivered by an amazing crew. Facilities include a sun deck with deck chairs and loungers, an international restaurant, a panoramic bar, a quiet lounge area, a fitness suite and a salon.

Could you share highlights of cruising specific rivers?
A personal favourite is the Danube from the elegance of imperial Vienna to the twin cities of Buda and Pest. Stepping back in time to the eras of the Ottoman Empire and the Kingdom of the Habsburgs are highlights.

Are there any lesser-known river cruise destinations you recommend?
Some of my lesser-known gems are the ancient French city of Bordeaux, sailing through the picturesque Gironde Estuary and along sections of the Garonne and Dordogne. It was great following the Médoc wine route, touring historic Roquetaillade Château, and experiencing a wine pairing session at a family-run farm.

REASONS TO SAIL ON THE DANUBE RIVER

The Danube is Europe's second-longest river, flowing through 10 countries and linking capitals like Vienna, Budapest, and Bratislava. It offers one of the most diverse scenic experiences, from grand cities to tranquil countryside.

Highlights:

- **The Wachau Valley** in Austria is a standout section, famed for its rolling vineyards, medieval towns, and historic monasteries such as Melk Abbey, an impressive Baroque landmark overlooking the river.
- **Vienna** was home to the Habsburg emperors and its imperial treasures, featuring the Schönbrunn Palace, St Stephen's Cathedral and the opulent Hofburg Palace, all reflect the city's rich cultural heritage.
- **Budapest** is breathtaking at night, with its illuminated skyline. The Hungarian Parliament building, Buda Castle and the Chain Bridge all create a spectacular reflection on the water.
- **The Danube Bend**, a stunning curve in the river near Visegrád, Hungary, where rolling hills and medieval ruins provide some of the most picturesque views along the entire river. This section is especially beautiful during autumn, when the fall foliage turns into vibrant shades of red and gold.

Best for:

- Travelers who appreciate a blend of cultural capitals, historic landmarks and idyllic rural scenery.


WACHAU VALLEY

Introducing our ships

At Vacations By Rail, we know that the itinerary and destination make up only part of the excellent cruise experience we strive for. On a cruise, your accommodation becomes part of the vacation, and your ship should be as comfortable, as luxurious and as elegant as possible – coincidentally, all things our exclusively chartered ships happen to be!

The Amadeus Fleet

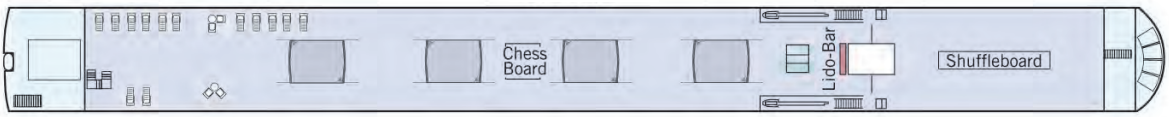
Amadeus ships are designed specifically to provide you with the highest level of comfort and convenience throughout the duration of your river cruise. Each ship has a range of excellent and well-maintained amenities and facilities, including:

- An elegant and spacious restaurant with floor-to-ceiling windows offering glorious views of the water and scenery.
- A tasteful bar and lounge below the Sun Deck, with panoramic windows and an outdoor seating area towards the front.
- An expansive Sun Deck with games and deckchairs – ideal for soaking up spellbinding views and socializing with new friends.
- The Amadeus Club, where you will find a library, games and a bar – the perfect place to enjoy a tranquil afternoon of sailing.
- The Café Vienna near the restaurant – for you to indulge in specialist coffees, cakes and biscuits throughout the day.
- A 24-hour reception area, attended by friendly members of staff who will check you on and off the ship for excursions or onshore leisure time.
- Onboard entertainment each evening, either from local artists or our own performers, beguiling you with classic numbers.
- A massage room offering for relaxing and purifying treatments, a hair salon, and a gym with cycling machines, treadmill and exercise balls.
- Bicycles for passengers who wish to venture further afield and explore the beautiful onshore surroundings on two wheels.
- Complimentary Wi-Fi throughout the ship.
- A laundry service available for passengers (payable onboard).



Amadeus Imperial deck plan*

Sun Deck



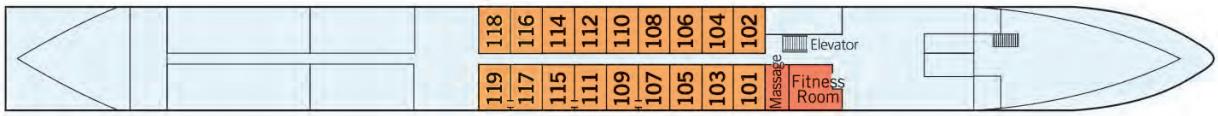
Upper Deck



Middle Deck



Lower Deck



SUITE & CABIN CATEGORIES

- **Deluxe Suite** Upper Deck
- **Deluxe Stateroom** Upper Deck
- **Deluxe Stateroom** Middle Deck
- **Classic Stateroom** Lower Deck

*Other ships all feature similar layouts.

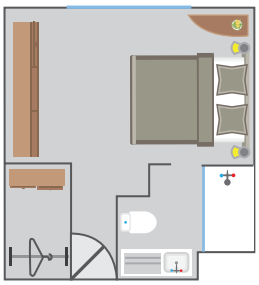


Selecting your cabin

When embarking on a luxury river cruise with us, we know your cabin is your home away from home. All our cabins are elegantly designed, promising an unforgettable river cruise experience.

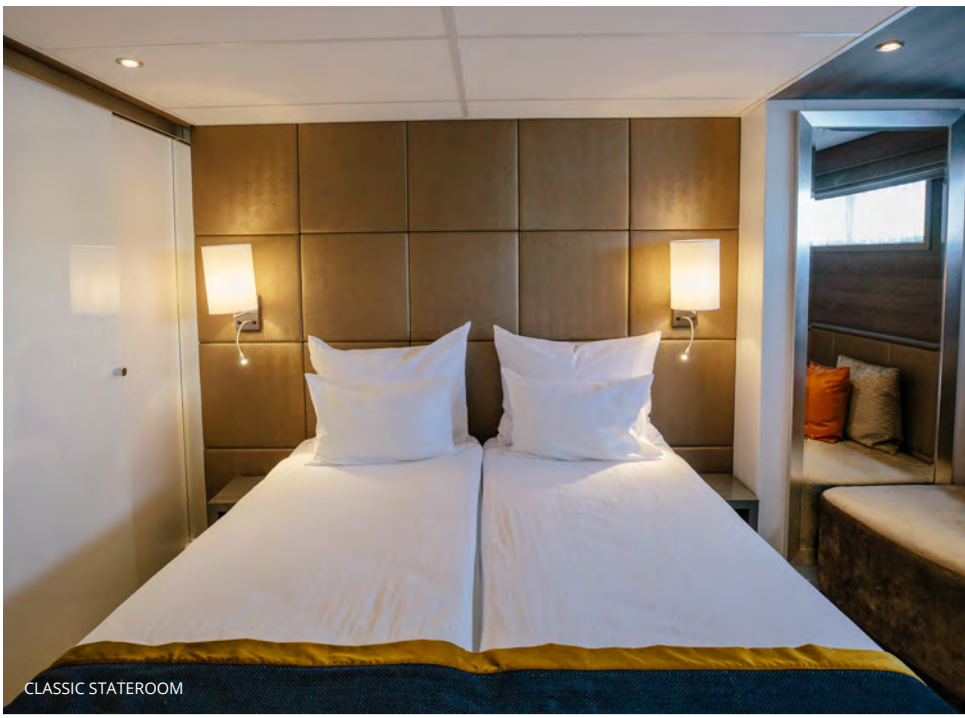
CLASSIC STATEROOM

16M² (172 SQ.FT)



Classic comfort, cosy cabins

Our well-appointed Classic Staterooms are on the lower deck and provide 172 sq.ft of comfort with a seating area and a spacious en suite bathroom.



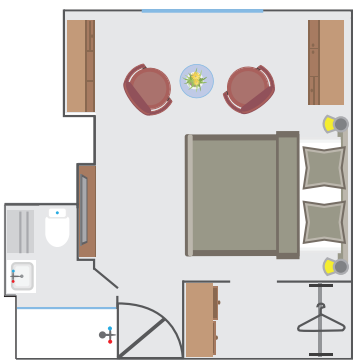
CLASSIC STATEROOM



DELUXE STATEROOM

DELUXE STATEROOM

17.5M² (188 SQ.FT)



Rooms with a view

For a special experience, the Deluxe Staterooms benefit from more space than other cruise ships. With a seating area and panoramic window these cabins are ideal for relaxation.


DELUXE SUITE



DELUXE SUITE

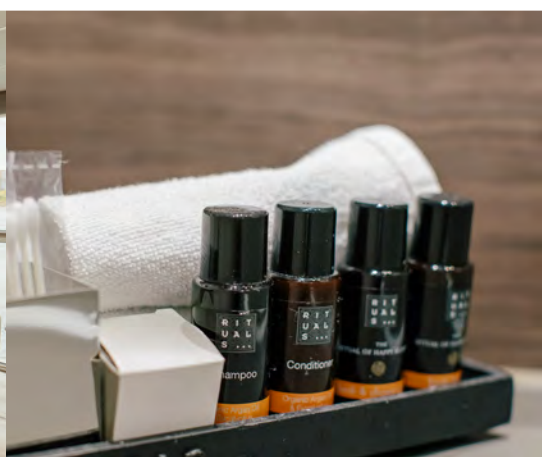
26.4M² (284 SQ.FT)

Living the suite life

For the ultimate in comfort, our Deluxe Suites are the largest onboard and feature unique touches for that extra opulence. Suites are located on the Upper Deck and come with incredible walk-out balconies, riverview soft seating areas and fluffy bathrobes.







All our cabins include:

- Egyptian cotton sheets
- Choice of bed configuration: double or twin bed
- Bathrooms with walk-in shower
- Complimentary toiletries
- Flatscreen TV
- Individual climate control
- Walk-in wardrobe
- Complimentary Wi-Fi
- Hairdryer
- Direct dial telephone
- In-room safe

Explore Europe's great rivers

Join us on an unforgettable cruise along one of Europe's magnificent rivers. Uncover fairytale castles on the enchanting Rhine, discover scenic vineyards along the Moselle and marvel at the timeless natural beauty of the Danube.
Sail through the Seine's artistic landscapes, sample fine French wines on the Rhône and Garonne, or follow Portugal's golden Douro to historic Porto.





The Rhine

We encounter the beauty and diversity of the Rhine in four countries. From the Swiss Alps to German castles, French vineyards to vibrant Dutch bulbfields we travel through fairytale scenery in the exquisite, UNESCO-listed Rhine Gorge.



The Moselle

This pretty tributary of the Rhine meanders through France, Luxembourg and Germany. We soak up local viticulture, admire small but majestic Luxembourg and delight in the enchanting villages and natural beauty of the Moselle's riverbanks.



The Danube

Each bend of the Danube reveals new surprises, from charming villages to the grand historic cities of Vienna, Budapest, and Bratislava. Nature enthusiasts will marvel at the scenic wonders while culture lovers will delight in its diversity.



The Rhine-Main-Danube Canal

This unique canal, connecting the three rivers of the Main, Rhine and Danube, runs from the historic German city of Bamberg, via Nuremberg, to Kelheim. The canal was fully opened in the early 1990s and offers a world of treasures to explore.



For our full list of river cruises go to
vacationsbyrail.com/cruises









The Seine

With iconic bridges and scenic banks, the romantic Seine is the epitome of cultural allure. Explore the world of the Impressionists, and the towns which inspired this artistic movement, from Giverny to the glorious galleries of Paris and Rouen.

The Rhône

Flowing through ancient picturesque landscapes, the Rhône gracefully connects nature with heritage. Starting in the Swiss Alps, it journeys south through cultural cities like Lyon and Avignon, finally embracing the Mediterranean Sea in southern France.

The Garonne

Adorning the banks of France's Garonne River are charming towns and lush vineyards. Drifting through its rustic landscapes, we savour the flavours and culture of wonderful places along the way – like Bordeaux, Cadillac, and Médoc.

The Douro

A captivating river that flows through the heartlands of Portugal. Drifting through golden valleys alongside enchanting towns and past regal wine estates, this serene river reveals a timeless beauty and historic ports.


"This was a wonderful adventure. It was very well organized with an interesting itinerary, lovely hotels, good food, inter-train travel and a lovely cruise and a beautiful ship. We had a great tour director. Everything was well thought out, all the excursions were included and we were well taken care of. I highly recommend this rail and cruise trip."
Grand Alpine Explorer & Delights of the Danube Cruise
Trustpilot
Excellent
BUDAPEST



ELEGANT, RELAXING, SCENIC

RIVER CRUISE

Glide gently through breathtaking landscapes and wake to stunning new destinations each day. Our luxury river cruises are a beautiful way to get straight to the heart of Europe's hidden gems. With 5-Star service onboard and spectacular excursions, unwind as this awe-inspiring continent unveils itself through unforgettable vistas.


GLACIER EXPRESS

11 DAYS FROM
$4,395

2026 Departures in:
MAY, JUN, JUL

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Riding the Glacier Express and Gornergrat Mountain Railway
- Admiring dramatic views while sailing through the Rhine Gorge
- Staying in the picturesque Swiss towns of Chur and Zermatt
- Discovering the beautiful town of Cochem on the Moselle River
- Exploring the Netherlands' cultural capital city, Amsterdam


CHUR

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**

Glacier Express and the Majestic Rhine

Discover the iconic Glacier Express train journey and enjoy a luxury Rhine cruise, from the historic streets of Chur and iconic peaks of Zermatt to the romantic Rhine Gorge.

YOUR ITINERARY

Days 1-2 – Iconic Glacier Express
Arrive at Zürich Airport and transfer on your own to Chur. On Day 2, we board the Glacier Express for panoramic journey through quintessential Swiss scenes of mountains, viaducts and tunnels on the way to Zermatt. Overnights Chur/Zermatt.

Day 3 – Gornergrat Mountain Railway
The second-highest railway in Europe, the cogwheel Gornergrat takes us high into the Swiss Alps today. At the top, stunning views of glaciers and the iconic Matterhorn are revealed. Returning to Zermatt, we embark on a guided tour. Overnight Zermatt.

Days 4-5 – Basel & the Black Forest
Traveling to Basel, we board our luxury ship ahead of our Rhine cruise. On Day 5, we reach Strasbourg, France. There's a choice of excursions. You could explore this grand city or journey deep into Germany's enchanting Black Forest. Overnights ship.

Days 6-7 – Heidelberg & Rhine Gorge
Waking in Speyer, you could opt for a guided tour of Heidelberg or discover Speyer at leisure. This evening, we arrive in the Rüdesheim. There's chance to explore after dinner. In Rüdesheim on Day 7, you can decide between a wine tasting or a visit to Siegfried's Mechanical Music Cabinet. This afternoon, we cruise the Rhine Gorge, famed for its breathtaking scenery and Lorelei Rock. There's free time later to explore Koblenz. Overnights ship.

Days 8-9 – Cochem & Cologne
Views of the Moselle guide us to Cochem, where a tour reveals half-timbered houses huddling under the imposing Reichsburg Castle. On Day 9, we dock in Königswinter for a ride on the Drachenfels railway, where great views can be absorbed from the summit. This evening, we arrive in Cologne for a guided city tour. Overnights ship.

Day 10 – Arrival into Amsterdam
Gliding into the Dutch capital, there are two options – touring cultural Amsterdam, or journeying on the Medemblik Steam Train through landscapes of windmills and tulips. A Dutch sea shanty choir performs as we enjoy our final dinner. Overnights ship.

Day 11 - Homeward bound
Disembarking today, you can transfer to Amsterdam airport for your journey home.


JUNGFRAU EXPRESS

Top of Europe & the Majestic Rhine Cruise

Experience the breathtaking 'Top of Europe' on the Jungfrau Express before a luxurious seven-night cruise along the Rhine River, visiting the charming towns and cities that line its banks.

YOUR ITINERARY

Days 1-2 – Jungfrau Express
Arriving at Zürich Airport, transfer on your own by rail to the scenic Swiss town of Interlaken. Day 2 sees us embark on a remarkable journey to the 'Top of Europe' on the Jungfrau Express – an unsung gem of Swiss mountain railways. At the top, the vistas of the Aletsch Glacier are truly awe-inspiring. Overnights Interlaken.

Days 3-4 – Our Rhine cruise begins
Traveling by rail to Basel, we board our luxury cruise ship and set sail along the Rhine this evening. Arriving in the French city of Strasbourg on Day 4, there's a choice of excursions. Select between a tour of Strasbourg or venturing into Germany's Black Forest. Overnights ship.

Days 5-6 – Rüdesheim & Rhine Gorge
Waking to views of charming Speyer, you can opt to spend time at leisure in this historic town or join a guided tour of Heidelberg. Gliding onward to Rüdesheim, you could stroll around this charming village famed for its dry Riesling wines. On Day 6, decide between a visit to Siegfried's Mechanical Music Cabinet or a wine tasting in Rüdesheim, before we sail on. This afternoon, we experience the beauty of the Rhine Gorge, where fairytale castles line the steep riverbanks, on our way to Koblenz. Overnights ship.

Days 7-8 – Exploring Cochem & Cologne
Setting sail early, our ship navigates the tranquil Moselle on the way to pretty Cochem. A tour reveals a maze-like Old Town nestled beneath the imposing Reichsburg Castle. Rejoining the Rhine, we ride the Drachenfels Railway on Day 8. Passing Drachenfels Castle, we reach the summit where incredible scenery is laid out before us. This evening, we embark on a guided tour of Cologne, including its Gothic cathedral. Overnights ship.

Day 9 – Amsterdam & Medemblik
Reaching Amsterdam, you have the choice of two exciting excursions. Select between a city tour of the Netherlands' cultural capital, or join the Medemblik Steam Train for a scenic journey through rural Dutch scenery. Overnight ship.

Day 10 – Homeward bound
Your cruise ends and you can transfer to the airport for your journey home.

10 DAYS FROM
$3,895

2026 Departures in:
MAY, JUN, JUL

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Traveling on the Jungfrau Express to the magical 'Top of Europe'
- Sailing by fairytale castles along the UNESCO-listed Rhine Gorge
- Enjoying a charming rail excursion on Germany's Drachenfels Railway
- Soaking in the atmosphere of Heidelberg, Rüdesheim & Cochem
- Spending two nights in the picturesque town of Interlaken


RÜDESHEIM

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**


KEUKENHOF GARDENS

Springtime Tulips & Keukenhof Gardens

8 DAYS FROM
$2,895

2026 Departures in:
APR

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Experiencing the spectacular blooms of the Keukenhof Gardens
- Discovering the fairytale city of Bruges on a sightseeing tour
- Visiting Ypres after an onboard talk by Col. Piers Storie-Pugh OBE
- Exploring the unique, cultural cityscape of Amsterdam
- Journeying on the vintage Medemblik Steam Train


AMSTERDAM

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**

Sail through Belgium and the Netherlands, delving into rich history, visiting beautiful gardens and discovering picturesque cities along the enchanting Rhine river.

YOUR ITINERARY

Day 1 – To our ship in Amsterdam
Meeting at London St Pancras, we travel via Eurostar to Amsterdam where we board our luxurious ship. Overnight ship.

Day 2 – Exploring Amsterdam
The Dutch capital is explored on a guided tour of the city's pretty canals and bridges. Enjoying a canal boat cruise, we get to see the sights of this attractive city, including the centuries-old houses that line the waterways. After lunch and free time, we set sail to Ghent in Belgium. Overnight ship.

Day 3 – Historic Ghent or Bruges
After breakfast, Colonel Piers Storie-Pugh comes aboard to deliver a fascinating talk about the region's battlefields. There's a choice of excursions later: touring medieval Bruges or exploring Ghent, one of Belgium's oldest cities. Overnight ship.

Day 4 – Ypres Battlefields or Ghent
An optional excursion this morning is to the poignant Ypres Battlefields, a key battlefront in World War One, including the Sanctuary Wood Cemetery with entrance included. Alternatively, explore attractive Ghent at your own pace. Overnight ship.

Day 5 – Battle of Arnhem or Dutch history
Your first option is to visit the excellent Hartenstein Airborne Museum focusing on the World War Two Battle of Arnhem. Alternatively, learn about the country's long history at the Netherlands' Open-Air Museum. Overnight ship.

Day 6 – Hoorn/Medemblik Steam Railway
The delightful harbor town of Hoorn greets us this morning and you can explore at leisure. An optional excursion is a nostalgic journey through the enchanting scenes of tulip fields and windmills aboard the Medemblik Steam Train. Overnight ship.

Day 7 – Beautiful Keukenhof Gardens
British horticulturist Charlie Dimmock joins us today for a presentation before a highlight of our trip. Touring the Keukenhof Gardens, we marvel at its decorative tulip displays. Tonight, we enjoy a gala dinner for our last night onboard. Overnight ship.

Day 8 – Homeward bound
We disembark this morning and return by rail to London where our tour concludes.


BRATISLAVA

The Classic Blue Danube Cruise

Relax and explore on a breathtaking cruise along the Danube, one of Europe's most diverse waterways, sailing through natural beauty and enjoying explorations of historic cities.

YOUR ITINERARY

Days 1-2 – From Passau to Linz
Landing in Munich, use your included rail ticket to travel to your luxurious ship in Passau. On Day 2, we begin our relaxing Danube cruise. Entering Austria, rising hills covered with vineyards and orchards create an idyllic backdrop. Our first destination is Linz, a lovely riverside town known for its Baroque architecture. Overnights ship.

Days 3-4 – Salzburg & Wachau Valley
A choice of excursion awaits today, picking between the Austrian Lake District, including the stunning village of Hallstadt, or joining a sightseeing tour of Salzburg, Mozart's hometown. On Day 4, we visit Melk Abbey, an 11th-century Benedictine Abbey that stands atop a rocky outcrop overlooking the Danube. After lunch, we cruise through the scenery of the Wachau Valley, truly a highlight of the river. This scenic area is a famous wine-making and we stop in Dürnstein for a tasting of some of the local varieties. Overnights ship.

Day 5 – Discovering magical Vienna
Reaching Austria's capital today, we set out on a tour of Vienna's grandeur, including the elegant imperial architecture of the Ringstrasse. Tonight, we are joined onboard by four previous members of the Vienna Philharmonic Orchestra who perform popular classical pieces. Overnights ship.

Day 6 – Enchanting Bratislava
The Slovakian capital is one of Europe's most beautiful cities and we enjoy a guided tour of Bratislava's Baroque Old Town and the castle district after lunch. Later, we continue to Hungary's former capital, Esztergom, for the night. Overnight ship.

Day 7 – Budapest, 'Pearl of the Danube'
The stunning Danube Bend guides us into Budapest today. This lively and elegant city is explored on a sightseeing tour on arrival, as we admire the ornate Parliament, St Stephen's Basilica and Fisherman's Bastion. After dinner, we enjoy an onboard performance by a traditional Hungarian Folklore troupe followed by an unforgettable nighttime cruise with the city's iconic illuminated buildings casting a glow on the Danube. Overnight ship.

Day 8 – Homeward bound
After breakfast, it's time to disembark and you are free to begin your journey home.

8 DAYS FROM
$1,995

2026 Departures in:
JUN, JUL, AUG

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Uncovering the incredible architecture of Budapest, Hungary
- Discovering Vienna's imperial grandeur on a sightseeing tour
- Visiting the 11th-century Melk Abbey in the Wachau Valley
- Admiring the spellbinding beauty of Slovakia's capital, Bratislava
- Experiencing the Baroque streets of Salzburg, Mozart's hometown


BUDAPEST

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**


PRAGUE

11 DAYS FROM
$3,795

2026 Departures in:
JUN, JUL, AUG, SEP

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Discovering medieval Prague and exploring its enchanting sights
- Uncovering emotive sites in the vibrant German capital, Berlin
- Admiring Budapest's beautiful architecture on a night cruise
- Touring the imperial Habsburg city of Vienna and its grand buildings
- Visiting captivating Salzburg or the breathtaking Austrian Lake District


VIENNA

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**

Imperial Cities & Delights of the Danube

Embrace the magic of the blue Danube and central Europe's imperial cities, traveling from Berlin and Prague to beautiful Budapest for a cruise through Vienna and Austria.

YOUR ITINERARY

Days 1-2 – Discovering Berlin
Your vacation begins on arrival in where you check in to your hotel. Setting out on a guided tour on Day 2, we discover Berlin's iconic landmarks, including the Brandenburg Gate and remnants of the Berlin Wall. After lunch, we travel by rail to Prague. Overnights Berlin/Prague.

Day 3 – Bohemian charms in Prague
Today we have the whole day ahead to explore Prague, including its majestic castle, the 14th-century Charles Bridge and the Old Town's astronomical clock. When the tour concludes, there's time to explore at leisure. Overnight Prague.

Days 4-5 – To Budapest and our boat
Continuing by rail, we reach Budapest, where our luxurious ship awaits. After dinner, there's a performance by a traditional Hungarian Folklore troupe. Once the sun sets, we begin a nighttime cruise along the Danube River, admiring the illuminated Parliament and Buda Castle. On Day 5, we embark on a guided tour, including St Stephen's Basilica and Fisherman's Bastion. Later, we set sail past the Danube Bend. Overnights ship.

Day 6 – Glorious Bratislava
Arriving in the Slovakian capital, we are welcomed by its castle overlooking the river. After lunch, we explore the idyllic Old Town and castle district before there is free time to wander Bratislava's beautiful streets. Overnight ship.

Day 7 – Imperial Vienna
This morning, we arrive in Vienna for a tour of its grand architecture, viewing the Opera House and Parliament before time at leisure. Tonight, four previous members of the Vienna Philharmonic Orchestra join us onboard to perform classical pieces. Overnight ship.

Days 8-9 – Wachau Valley & Austrian lake district
Famed for its wine, there's time to explore independently in quaint Dürnstein, before we sail through the scenic Wachau Valley. Later, we visit 11th-century Melk Abbey. On Day 9, there's a choice of excursions – to Mozart's hometown of Salzburg or the Austrian Lake District. Overnights ship.

Days 10 – Homeward bound
Your cruise concludes in Passau today and you can return home at leisure.


SINTRA

Lisbon & Premium Golden Douro

Explore Portugal's capital before setting sail aboard a luxurious new ship – custom-built to navigate the Douro – on a seven-night cruise through one of Europe's oldest wine regions.

YOUR ITINERARY

Days 1-3 – Lisbon & Sintra
Arriving in Portugal, transfer independently to our Lisbon hotel. Our tour of Lisbon on Day 2 features a trip in a vintage tram as we explore cinematic streets before concluding with a tasting of Belém pastries. On Day 3, we travel to Sintra for time at leisure to explore the kaleidoscopic hilltop palaces. Overnights Lisbon.

Day 4 – Our cruise begins in Porto
Traveling by rail to historic Porto, we board our luxury ship for dinner. With just 60 cabins, the MS Estrela is an intimate and sociable way of exploring this beautiful valley. Before our first dinner aboard we enjoy a stunning introduction to Porto on a sunset cruise. Overnight ship.

Days 5-6 – Lamego & Castelo Rodrigo
Setting sail during breakfast, you could enjoy a Portuguese language lesson before we arrive in Peso da Régua. From here, we visit Lamego Cathedral, founded in 1129 by Portugal's first king. This evening, we transfer to a quinta to enjoy a traditional Portuguese dinner. On Day 6, we explore Castelo Rodrigo, a historic walled town of stone cottages and cobbled alleyways perched on a hilltop. Overnights ship.

Day 7 – 'Golden City' of Salamanca
Venturing into Spain, we explore the country's academic capital, Salamanca. Our guided tour showcases the ornate House of Shells and the Plaza Mayor. During lunch at a restaurant, we enjoy a flamenco performance before returning to our ship for a barbecue on deck. Overnight ship.

Day 8 – The port wine route
Our cruise back downstream takes us through scenic landscapes to Peso da Régua to discover the town's connection to port wine. Later, we experience this famed produce during a tasting. Overnight ship.

Days 9-10 – Mateus Palace & Porto
After breakfast, we join an excursion to Mateus Palace – an 18th-century masterpiece with a classic Italianate exterior. Sailing along the Douro, we enjoy a four-course Captain's Dinner followed by a Portuguese folk music show. Back in Porto on Day 10, there's a choice of excursions: a tour of Porto with port wine-tasting or a visit to Guimarães. Overnights ship.

Day 11 – Homeward bound
Your Douro vacation concludes and you can fly home from Porto at leisure.

11 DAYS FROM
$4,395

2026 Departures in:
MAY, JUNE, OCT

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Embarking in five-star luxury on the custom-built MS Estrela
- Enjoying the flavors of Portuguese and Mediterranean cuisine
- Touring Lisbon's colourful streets and Sintra's dazzling palaces
- Viewing Porto on an evening cruise as the sun casts a glow on the river
- Tasting authentic port wine and dining at a traditional quinta


MS ESTRELA

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**


RHINE IN FLAMES

SEASONAL EVENT

8 DAYS FROM
$3,795

2026 Departures in:
SEP

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Experience the incredible Rhine in Flames procession, an annual spectacle along the Rhine River
- Sail through this Rhine Gorge UNESCO World Heritage site where spellbinding castles abound
- Uncover fairytale landscapes on a cog railway journey to the summit of the majestic Drachenfels


DRACHENFELSBAHN

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**

The Rhine Valley in Flames

Discover the picturesque scenery of the magical Rhine on a spectacular cruise and watch as the river bursts to life in a show of color during the Rhine in Flames celebration.

YOUR ITINERARY

Day 1 – Boarding our ship in Cologne
Your cruise vacation begins at London St. Pancras station as we board the Eurostar to Brussels. Continuing by rail, we reach Cologne, where we board our luxury ship and enjoy our first five-course dinner.

Day 2 – Riding the Drachenfelsbahn
After breakfast, we join a guided tour of Cologne, admiring sights including the twin-spired Gothic cathedral before savoring a tasting of chocolate. Later, we set sail to Königswinter, where we board the Drachenfels cog railway. Rising high into the forests, we pass the fairytale Drachenfels castle and experience wonderful views at the summit.

Day 3 – Watching the Rhine in Flames
There's time at leisure to explore historic Koblenz, before we cruise to Oberwesel. A tour highlight awaits after dinner as we enjoy the Rhine in Flames event. Locals and visitors celebrate summer with illuminated boats, fireworks and music along the Rhine. We have a great vantage point from our ship as the sky lights up and the river shimmers with colors.

Day 4 – Rhine Gorge & Rüdesheim
A leisurely start greets us today as we sail through the UNESCO-listed Rhine Gorge, famed for its castles, vineyards and the mythical Lorelei Rock. Docking in Rüdesheim, there's a choice of excursions. You can opt to join a winery tour followed by a tasting or visit Siegfried's Mechanical Music Cabinet.

Day 5 – Heidelberg or Speyer
Arriving in Mannheim, we continue to Heidelberg for a guided tour of this ancient town renowned for its red sandstone castle. Alternatively, stay on board as the ship sails to Speyer, with chance to visit the striking cathedral.

Day 6 – Sailing to Strasbourg
A full day on the Rhine allows us to soak in the scenery before we arrive in the French city of Strasbourg, where there's time to explore before dinner.

Day 7 – Black Forest or Strasbourg
On the final day of the cruise, there's a choice of excursions. The first is a trip into the Black Forest, Germany's largest nature park. Alternatively, join a tour of Strasbourg to discover an attractive city blending French and German heritage. Tonight is our special gala dinner.

Day 8 – Homeward bound
Your cruise concludes today as we travel from Strasbourg to Paris, continuing by Eurostar to London St. Pancras.


NEUSCHWANSTEIN CASTLE

NEW FOR 2026

Munich, Bavaria & the Beautiful Danube

Explore the history and culture of Bavaria, spending 3-nights in Munich with a visit the fairytale Neuschwanstein Castle. Then embark on a 7-night luxury Danube River cruise visiting renowned cities of Vienna, Budapest, and more.

YOUR ITINERARY

Days 1-2 – Exploring Munich
Your European adventure begins as you land in Munich, the capital of Bavaria, and check in to our hotel ahead of dinner. On Day 2, we tour this historic city, sampling local food and beer at Munich's oldest beer hall.

Day 3 – Neuschwanstein Castle
Bavaria's most famous castle is our destination after breakfast. With entrance included, we explore the fairytale Neuschwanstein Castle, viewing its soaring towers and turrets that inspired Disney's Sleeping Beauty.

Day 4 – Boarding our ship in Passau
After a leisurely morning, we travel by train to the town of Passau on the border between Germany and Austria. Here, we board our luxurious ship ahead of our Danube cruise.

Day 5 – Austria's scenic Wachau Valley
A visit to the 11th-century Melk Abbey signals our arrival in the beautiful Wachau Valley. There's free time in Dürnstein before we sail to Vienna.

Day 6 – Discovering imperial Vienna
Austria's capital was the home of the Habsburg empire and our tour of the elegant Ringstrasse reveals iconic buildings including the Opera House and Parliament, before free time.

Day 7 – Exploring regal Budapest
Arriving in the Hungarian capital after lunch, a sightseeing tour unveils impressive sights such as St. Stephen's Basilica and Fisherman's Bastion. Later, a nighttime cruise shows us the illuminated attractions of Budapest including the spellbinding Parliament.

Day 8 – Sailing the Danube Bend
A free morning in Budapest is followed by a scenic cruise through the Danube Bend, passing historic Esztergom, as we head towards Slovakia's capital.

Day 9 – Beautiful Bratislava
Overlooked by its picture-perfect hilltop castle, a tour of enchanting Bratislava uncovers Baroque buildings lining idyllic cobblestone streets.

Day 10 – Uncovering the city of Linz
Our final full day begins with a cruise to Linz, which we discover on a guided tour before our gala dinner onboard.

Day 11 – Homeward bound
Reaching Passau, your cruise concludes and you can make your way to the airport to begin your journey home.

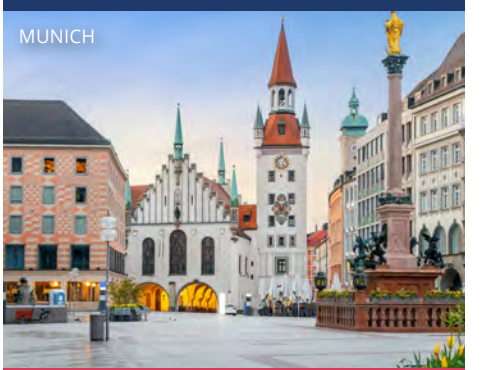
11 DAYS FROM
$3,495

2026 Departures in:
JUN, JUL, AUG

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Climb into the foothills of the Alps to Neuschwanstein Castle, a fairytale 19th-century castle
- Immerse yourself in sensational Budapest, Hungary's capital, dubbed the "Pearl of the Danube"
- Discover Vienna's imperial grandeur as we wander the Austrian capital's Baroque streets


MUNICH

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**



11 DAYS FROM
$4,295

2026 Departures in:
APR, JUN, JUL, AUG, SEP

ESCORTED

UNFORGETTABLE EXPERIENCES

- Witness opulence in its grandest form while touring the 17th-century Palace of Versailles
- Discover the Burgundy town of Beaune on a sightseeing tour and a tasting of its renowned wines
- Explore the highlights of Lyon, from its UNESCO-listed Old Town to its modern gastronomic side


PALACE OF VERSAILLES

To book and for more information, go to **vacationsbyrail.com** or call **877-253-9891**

Paris, Provence & the Elegant Rhône

Spend 3-nights in Paris, exploring its iconic sights and elegant streets, before embarking on a 7-night luxury Rhône River cruise through Provence, featuring stunning landscapes, historic towns, and world-class cuisine.

YOUR ITINERARY

Days 1-2 – Paris, the "City of Love"
Your vacation begins in Paris. After meeting the group, we dine together. On Day 2, we view famed landmarks, including the Eiffel Tower, Arc du Triomphe and Notre-Dame Cathedral.

Day 3 – Royal Palace of Versailles
This 17th-century masterpiece is our destination today. With a Passport Ticket, we have priority access to the ornate palace and manicured gardens recalling the reign of Louis XIV.

Day 4 – Boarding our ship in Lyon
Travelling by First Class rail, we reach the city of Lyon on the River Rhône. Our crew welcomes onboard our luxury ship before sail towards Chalon-sur-Saône.

Day 5 – Burgundy wine region
Transferring by coach to Beaune, we uncover a classic French medieval town with an incredible wine heritage. As we explore, we enjoy a tasting of delectable Burgundy wines.

Day 6 – Guided tour of Lyon
Arriving back in Lyon after an overnight cruise, we explore the city's highlights, including its UNESCO-listed Old Town. Our tour concludes with a praline tasting before we sail through idyllic scenery.

Day 7 – Riding the Train de l'Ardèche
In Tournon, we board the spectacular Train de l'Ardèche for a heritage journey through the Gorges du Doux. Returning to our ship, we set sail for Avignon.

Day 8 – Avignon, the City of Popes
A guided tour begins with a trip on Le Petit Train as we set out to discover this stately city. Entry is included to the Pope's Palace, which was the seat of the Catholic Church in the 14th century.

Day 9 – Arrival in artistic Arles
A walking tour of Arles reveals its Roman history and locations that inspired Van Gogh. There are two optional excursions this afternoon. Choose between the wildlife-rich Camargue Delta or the iconic Pont du Gard.

Day 10 – "Europe's Grand Canyon"
A trip to the stunning Ardèche Gorge reveals an area of snaking rivers and ravines before we reach the Pond d'Arc. Later, we visit the Provençal Lavender Museum before our gala dinner.

Day 11 – Homeward bound
Your sensational exploration of France concludes in Lyon. Saying farewell to our crew, we travel by First Class rail to Paris, where you can make your way home.

About Vacations By Rail


LONDON

For more than 20 years, Vacations By Rail has been showing people the best of the world. Whether you are planning a getaway with a loved one, a guided city escape, or the trip of a lifetime, we curate experiences for every individual and every type of vacation.

Our core belief has remained the same: the journey itself should be a part of the adventure. From the luxurious Rocky Mountaineer through the stunning Canadian Rockies to the awe-inspiring Swiss Alps aboard the Glacier Express, traveling with us allows you to discover incredible parts of the world from a unique perspective.

With our escorted rail vacations, river cruises, and independent vacations, we provide thousands of travelers each year with unforgettable experiences, various transportation choices, and amazing accommodations. While you choose from the biggest selection of rail vacations and cruises, our dedicated rail specialists are there to guide you through questions and bookings.

Using our expertise in global destinations, we create seamless itineraries to ensure you get the best experience in your chosen location. Booking with us adds an effortless and exciting element to your journey, no matter where your explorations take you.

A popular feature of our escorted vacations and river cruises is the presence of a knowledgeable Tour Manager who accompanies you throughout the entire journey. Our customers appreciate the personalized touch this adds to their excursions and how it simplifies the process of moving between destinations. Your Tour Manager is always available to handle all the details, ensuring you can enjoy your trip with complete peace of mind.

Vacations By Rail is a premier small group and independent tour operator, as well as North America's trusted authority on rail. Vacations By Rail offers travelers the largest selection of curated independent vacations, escorted group tours and luxury rail journeys. The company is committed to delivering innovative, fresh itineraries that center around unique and immersive ways to explore the world.

Vacations By Rail is owned by UK-based Great Rail Journeys, an award-winning tour operator with more than 50 years of experience in curating escorted tours.

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COLOGNE

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COVER: BUDAPEST